
“I believe that [Lincoln] liked me personally, and ... he was always **much influenced by me.**”

MCCLELLAN RECALLING HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH PRESIDENT LINCOLN

George Brinton McClellan served as the talented, if mercurial, father of the Army of the Potomac. He also became the political standard bearer for the significant minority of Northerners who believed in the Union, but deemed it unproductive and unconstitutional to make emancipation a war goal.

Intelligent and precocious, McClellan completed his military training at West Point in 1846 at the age of 19. He came second out of a class of 59 graduates, and his peers included Thomas “Stonewall” Jackson, George Pickett, and his successor at the head of the Army of the Potomac, Ambrose Burnside. The War with Mexico began the year he graduated, and McClellan served as an engineer officer in General Winfield Scott’s Veracruz campaign. He compiled an excellent combat record, winning two brevet (acting) promotions.

After the War with Mexico ended, McClellan was sent by Secretary of War Jefferson Davis to observe the Crimean War. He left the Army in 1857 and became head of the Illinois Central Railroad, remaining a railroad man until the outbreak of the Civil War, when he returned to the Army as commander of the Ohio Volunteers. McClellan had voted for Stephen Douglas in the 1860 election, and while he had no sympathies for anti-slavery causes, like Douglas, he remained a strong Union man.